

Brunswick Street

Art & Revolution

Anne Rittman

Maz Wilson

Black Pepper
Melbourne, Australia







rhumbarellas

suzi alesandra

I lived in North Fitzroy and by a miracle was offered the means to start a cafe. Shukri, a mere acquaintance at that time, appeared just as I planned to seek a premises via a real estate agent. He asked if I would help him run an art gallery. When I explained that I was going to run a cafe, he suggested I put it in his gallery. It turned out to be a double-fronted place he'd found just down the road in Brunswick street.

Brunswick Street was a bleak and desolate street, with rumbling trams and dusty warehouses. The council had had all the Victorian verandahs pulled down. There were a couple of greasy fish and chip shops, and two cool cafes – Bakers and the Black

Cat. Those cafes were kind of exclusive – studious types seemed to prefer Bakers and groovy retro types frequented the Black Cat. I was fascinated by the fact that standing in the middle of the street outside Rhumbas you could see a church spire rising up out of each end of the street.

So the gallery idea invited the cafe, thanks to Shukri's vision.

With the help of friends including my mother, I was fixing up the space, scrubbing down burnt chairs which we got for \$2 each at an auction, painting the walls, getting the bar built, plumbing and electrics installed and people kept dropping in asking 'what's the concept?' I had no idea but being thereby forced to articulate something, I realised I wanted a place where everyone would feel comfortable (my

mother, my children, the homeless, the after-theatre crowd, the dazed morning-after coffee seekers, etc), which was always open (so people didn't have to figure out what day it was, what time it was, when all they wanted was to stagger down the street and get a coffee) and where folks could be as healthy and decadent as they felt like. At that time my kitchen seemed to be constantly full of visitors so I decided to supply what I'd serve up at home – or would like to serve up. So it became unique for its time, serving the best healthy stuff alongside the most decadently delicious – the best coffee and bancha tea, homemade pasta and brown rice (you could have pasta sauce on a bowl of it), freshly made juices – and rich delicious cakes (made in my kitchen by beautiful beings who let my children help and one of whom sang arias all the while) with homemade icecream from Charmaines up the road.

So interestingly, the concept was 'no concept', which turned out to be a great concept!

Another aspect which enhanced the vibe and the appearance was the staff which mostly consisted of women, my friends and others – artists, musicians, actors, dancers. They created an atmosphere of beauty, mystery and excitement – the vibrations of the Goddess. They came with their creativity. Late one night the place was full and Jules Materia decided to take a breather and began to dance in her Isadora Duncan style among the tables and around the poles.

The first Sunday morning – I thought no-one would come as the street was empty, but the cafe became full to overflowing. I remember Mary Gallic in a little black cocktail hat with a fascinator. There was just me and Mary, trying to do everything – take orders, make food and coffee, wash dishes. John Pinder suddenly stood up at his table and yelled in total frustration: 'Is this a business or somebody's private circus?' Which was funny as he had The Last Laugh where I saw the Circus of Oz. I said: 'Enjoy the circus John.' Then I called out: 'Does anyone here know how to make coffee?' and Steve McCarthy, an artist and friend, who was working at the Black Cat, rolled up his sleeves and parked himself behind the coffee machine for the rest of the morning. We had an old machine with the big pull-down levers at that time. That was one of the greatest highlights for me!

The greatest highlight of all was the arrival of a very serious Peter Sellers look-alike with horn-rimmed glasses looking for work. It was Yorgos. My friend Elizabeth Huntley is credited with this miraculous manifestation. I didn't think he'd fit in but Elizabeth, who was normally very quiet and gentle, said 'Suzi, give him a job! He's ethical and honest'. She grasped my hands, leaning over the table. She was so intense that I surrendered to her will and did as she demanded! She didn't say how experienced he was managing classy restaurants in London, with an economics degree to boot. He was also very humble and worked diligently as a waiter until I began to discern his worth and let him manage for me, eventually becoming my partner. My dear friend Kaye Ashton had also become indispensable, managing for me on the weekends so that I could have some time off with my children, Sunnie and Emma. They were about 8 and 11 respectively, and used to help out in the cafe. Sunnie used to stand on a milk crate and make coffees, pulling down the lever with all her might.

I believe the whole thing was under grace. I don't remember any dark moments. It was a lot of fun and hard work. I did it with a passion and never thought it would be profitable. I was happy to earn a living and pay the wages and bills. It effected everyone who got involved and people still appear in unexpected contexts and tell me how important it was in their lives.

I believe its great positive influence and success was the fruit of the seed it grew from – it was borne of a wish and a prayer on my part, fulfilled by the love and generosity and madness of a great man, a Viennese gentleman and Canberran of the Year, an equestrian who loved to Tango – Gus Petersilka. One of the first things Gus said to me was 'I am an instrument of God!' Another was that I should run a cafe.

Coincidentally I had harboured a secret desire to do so but didn't have the means or experience. Gus thought experience wasn't necessary and that running cafes was the only career in life worth pursuing, which he did until his death in 1994 aged 76. Gus sent me a cheque for \$1000 a week, for months – it eventually amounted to \$25,000 – interest free, no strings and never a contract. After 4

months in business I realised I could afford to repay him at the rate of \$140 a week – which I did. By then he was in Vienna with a young wife, a baroness called Andrea.

My ex-husband, artist Dom de Clario offered to paint the place. I was happy with my cerise walls, kind of dark and Viennese, but I welcomed Dom's inspiration. I learned at the very beginning of this adventure, which was meeting Gus, that all I had to do was say 'OK'. The Universe had taken things in hand and everything was 'in the flow' as it were. Dom painted ships and messages and mysterious lines and electric wires connecting lights and mysterious symbols, all on a very happy background of light blue. It looked wonderful and remained for years.





yorgis tserexidis

I arrived in Melbourne in early 1984 and through common friends I was introduced to Suzi Alesandra. Suzi asked me to help her run this new cafe she had just started in Brunswick Street - Rhumbarella's Cafe! At first I said no, I wasn't sure I wanted to stay in Melbourne. Melbourne seemed too quiet for my liking, I wanted to go back to Europe. Then, I started falling in love with the street and its wonderful early inhabitants!

Soon enough I accepted Suzi's generous offer to become partners and I never looked back! Brunswick Street looked like a neglected village to me! It had a rundown look about it, with many shopfronts boarded up. A few old businesses were still there, struggling to attract customers. And then there were the new tenants, new businesses run by creative and daring individuals. In our part of the street we had Dizzy Spinners, Charmaines Ice Cream, Maxines, The Fitz and many others. The street's best attraction was, of course, the people it attracted; a wonderfully diverse bohemia! Artists, crooks and drunks, mixing it with the students and the old residents of Fitzroy, as well as the 'tourists', from other, wealthier suburbs of Melbourne.